

The Case of the Missing Milk Packets

Taruna, Nitya, Vinod, and Rahul were playing near their apartment complex one evening. Taruna and Nitya were on the **swing** while Vinod and Rahul were playing with the fallen seeds of the eucalyptus tree that grew in the compound.

"I wish we had a good football to play with," **sighed** Nitya, who loved to run around.

"Did you know that somebody took Smita aunty's milk packets this morning?" said Taruna again.

Vinod **noded**. "I believe it has happened many times this month," he said.

"It could be a hungry monkey who likes milk!" said Rahul.

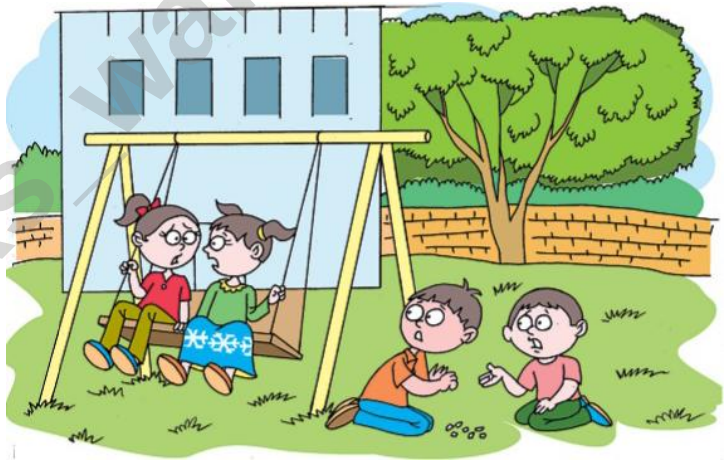
"Don't be silly!" said Vinod. "If a monkey had taken the packets, it would have spilt milk all over the place. I **bet** the thief's a human!"

"I agree," said Taruna. "Wouldn't it be fun to catch the **culprit**?"

The four looked at each other excitedly.

"That would be great! But how?" asked Nitya.

"Nitya, since Smita aunty lives on your floor, can you go this evening and get all the facts?" suggested Taruna. "Rahul could question our security guard, Ramiah. And let's meet tomorrow evening and discuss."



Nitya got unexpected help from her mother who asked her to give some **payasam** to Smita aunty.

"Payasam! How nice!" said Smita aunty, opening the door. "Come in, let me get you a chocolate."

When she returned with the chocolate, Nitya said, "Aunty, I heard that somebody has been stealing milk from your doorstep."

"Yes," replied Smita aunty. "It has happened 10 times this month."

"What time is the milk delivered?" asked Nitya.

"Around 5:45 AM. Govindappa leaves it in the basket outside my door. My **maid** comes around 6:30 AM and brings the milk in."

The next day, Rahul casually asked Ramiah, "Uncle, did you know that somebody is stealing milk?"

"Yes, yes," replied Ramiah, looking **hassled**. "We have four milk vendors, three boys who deliver newspapers and two flower **vendors** who come in the morning. Any of them could have taken it. It's impossible to check them all."

"Has it ever happened before?" asked Rahul.

"Not in the three years I have been here," said Ramiah.

That evening, the four friends **huddled** together and went over the information excitedly.

"Hmm. It must be one of the vendors," said Taruna.

"Since this has happened only in the last one month, let's find out which vendor is new on the job," suggested Vinod.

"Brilliant idea," said Taruna.

Rahul found out from Ramiah that one of the milk vendors had begun to serve their complex only since the previous month.

"I bet it's one of them," said Vinod. "But how do we prove it?"

Taruna thought of a plan, and all four took permission from their parents to exercise at 5:30 in the morning. Then, Nitya and Vinod **hid** near Smita aunty's front door while the other two stayed downstairs to be of help if required.

Two days went by without any clue of the thief.

It happened on the morning of the third day! Fifteen minutes after the milk was delivered, Nitya and Vinod watched Raja, the new milk vendor, **approach** Smita aunty's door. Their hearts **thumped** as Raja looked around **furtively** and quickly picked up the milk packet outside Smita aunty's door, put it into his bag, and walked away.

Quickly, they **alerted** the others and ran to Ramiah and asked him to stop Raja. Ramiah called Smita aunty to confirm if the milk had been stolen that day. Unable to understand what was happening, she came down and joined the kids at the gate.



By that time, a few other residents had also **gathered** there. As expected, Raja **vehemently** denied having taken the milk.

The cautious elders advised the children not to make **accusations** without having **sound** proof.

"But we can prove it!" said Taruna **triumphantly**. "Ask him to open his milk bag!"

Raja opened it for all to see. It was full of half and one-litre packets of the local brand.

Nitya reached in for a packet and held it high for all to see the letters "TVNR" written on it!

Raja looked confused, as did the others.

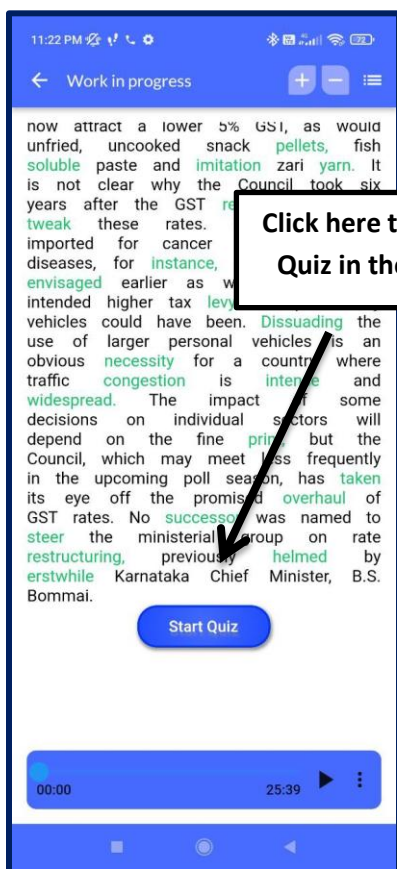
"TVNR stands for Taruna, Vinod, Nitya and Rahul!" said Taruna proudly. "Vinod wrote the letters on the packet this morning after Govindappa delivered it!"

The elders began to laugh at the **clever** way the children had succeeded in **catching** the thief **red-handed** — and Smita aunty gifted them a brand new football.

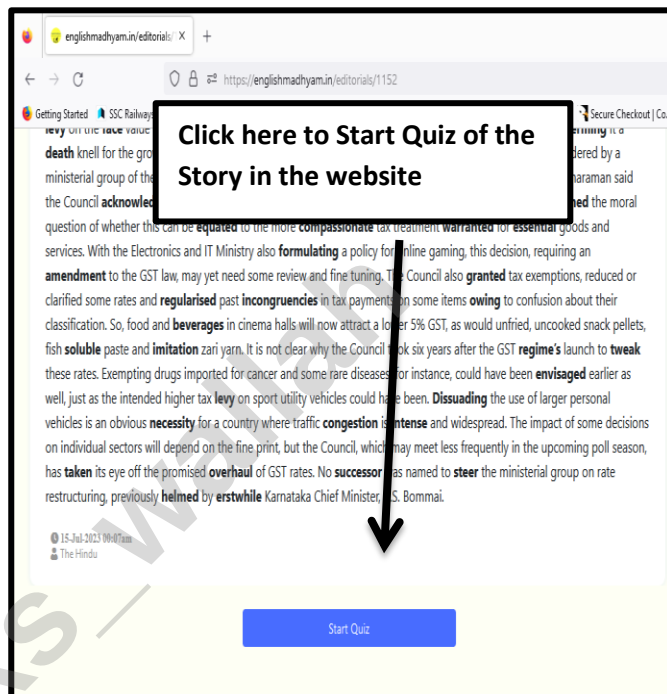
Vocabulary

1. **Swing** (noun) – seesaw, glider, rocker, playground seat, pendulum – झूला
2. **Sigh** (verb) – exhale, breathe out, murmur, moan, gasp – आह भरना
3. **Nod** (verb) – gesture, signal, bow, dip, incline – सिर हिलाना (हां में)
4. **Bet** (verb) – wager, gamble, stake, guess, predict – शर्त लगाना
5. **Culprit** (noun) – offender, criminal, wrongdoer, perpetrator, lawbreaker – दोषी
6. **Payasam** (noun) – kheer, sweet pudding, dessert, rice pudding, milk sweet – पायसम (दक्षिण भारतीय मिठाई)
7. **Maid** (noun) – servant, housekeeper, domestic helper, cleaner, assistant – नौकरानी
8. **Hassle** (verb) – bother, trouble, pester, annoy, disturb – तंग करना
9. **Vendor** (noun) – seller, trader, hawker, dealer, merchant – विक्रेता
10. **Huddle** (verb) – gather, crowd, cluster, group, assemble – झुंड में इकट्ठा होना
11. **Hide** (verb) – conceal, cover, mask, secrete, screen – छिपना
12. **Approach** (verb) – come near, move toward, reach, advance, draw near – पास आना
13. **Thump** (verb) – beat, pound, hammer, knock, throb – धड़कना / थपथपाना
14. **Furtively** (adverb) – secretly, stealthily, slyly, surreptitiously, sneakily – चुपके से
15. **Alter** (verb) – change, modify, adjust, transform, revise – बदलना
16. **Gather** (verb) – assemble, collect, accumulate, congregate, muster – इकट्ठा होना
17. **Vehemently** (adverb) – forcefully, passionately, fiercely, angrily, intensely – जोरदार तरीके से
18. **Accusation** (noun) – allegation, charge, blame, claim, complaint – आरोप
19. **Sound** (adjective) – reliable, solid, strong, valid, trustworthy – मजबूत / विश्वसनीय
20. **Triumphantly** (adverb) – victoriously, successfully, proudly, joyfully, exultantly – विजयी भाव से
21. **Clever** (adjective) – smart, intelligent, witty, resourceful, sharp – चतुर
22. **Catch someone red-handed** (phrase) – catch in the act, catch committing, catch in the moment, nab, apprehend – रंगे हाथ पकड़ना

Practice Exercise



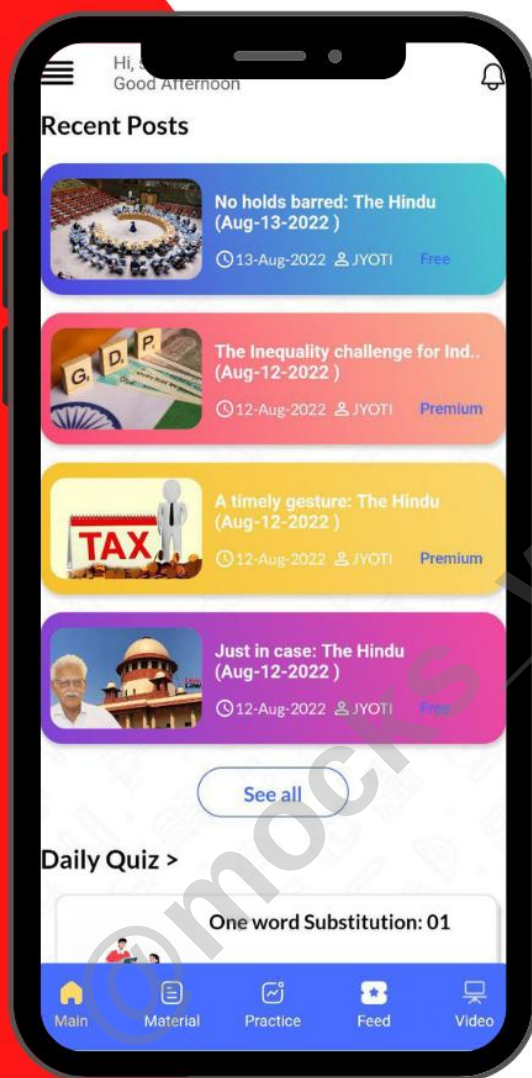
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